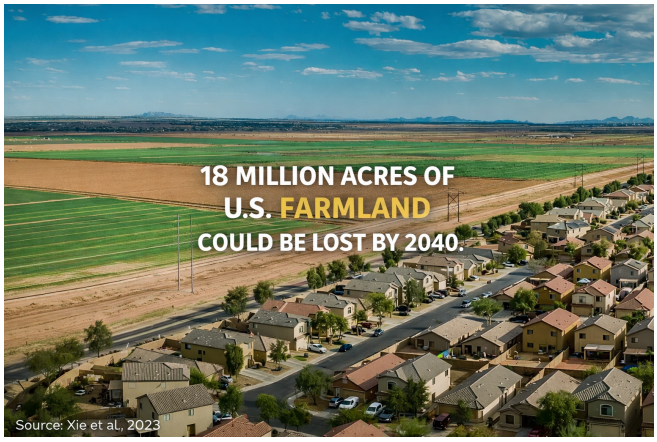
Stop Paving Over the Land That Feeds Us: Why Farmland Loss Should Concern Everyone

By Gavin Cochran

If you drive through almost any rural town today, you can see the same pattern repeating itself. A field that once grew some type of crop, or a pasture where cattle use to graze suddenly becomes a construction site for a new housing development. Within a year there will be a small community and potentially other projects such as shopping centers, gas stations, etc in the works on the land that use to produce our food. While development is a normal part of our economic growth as a nation, the continued loss of farmland is becoming a serious issue that threatens our food supply, rural communities, and long term economic stability.

I personally care about this issue because agriculture is the building blocks of both our food system and many rural economies. When farmland disappears, it is not just the land that is lost but also the community values as well. Coming from a cattle farming family, this hits home to me as I've seen many farmers sell of their land and lose their way of life. This also adds to the loss of the identity of our rural communities. In many cases, the farmland being developed is some of the most productive land available, which makes the consequences even more concerning.

Research shows us that farmland across the United States is steadily at risk of urban development. One study found that up to 18 million acres of U.S. agricultural land could be affected by urbanization by 2040 if current development trends continue (Xie et al., 2023). A lot of this development is occurring in areas already experiencing increased population growth, where farmland sits near expanding metropolitan areas.



The problem isn't just the land being lost but the production as well. Urban development often targets farmland that is the most productive. As cities continue to grow, farmland that is near

metropolitan areas can be converted into housing developments, infrastructure, as well commercial spaces. Once this land is developed, it wont return to agricultural production. Unlike temporary land use changes, urbanization often creates permanent new land uses such as roads and buildings that make future farming nearly impossible.

Farmland loss also carries a ton of economic consequences. Agricultural land generates revenue through food production as well as blue collar employment, When farmland is converted for urban use, these economic benefits are lost. Research modeling urban expansion in California's San Joaquin Valley found that status quo development patterns consumed the most farmland and resulted in the highest potential losses in agricultural revenue (Roth et al., 2012). The study also showed that smaller development strategies could reduce infrastructure costs and protect farmland at the same time.

Another important part of farmland loss is its impact on the farmers themselves. While development may sometimes provide short term financial benefits to landowners, it does not always improve their overall well being. A study examining farmers who recently sold their land found that although land conversion increased household income in some cases, it also reduced reported happiness among farmers (Wang et al., 2019). Ive seen this from a personals standpoint come from unfair land compensation as well as just the mental stress at the loss of a livelihood. Most if not all of these farmers have done this their whole life.

One time when I was younger I use to go to this pumpkin patch with my family every year, however in high school they sold their land for a new highway in our area. This loss of a place I had memories deeply effected me and my family because when you take farmland away you take away part of the community. Rural regions often depend on farming as a central part of their culture, identity, and economy. When farmland disappears, communities may lose jobs, agricultural infrastructure, and long standing traditions tied to farming like county fairs as well as harvest season activities such as agrotourism. Over time, this can weaken the economy of that rural areas and reduce local food production capacity.

For many people living in cities, farmland loss may feel like a small issue that doesn't matter. However, it ultimately affects everyone who depends on food systems which is a majority of this county. Agricultural land again provides the building blocks for food production, and protecting

that land helps ensure a long- erm food security. As populations grow were gonna have to provide more food, so preserving productive farmland becomes even more important.

Despite the intensity of the issue, farmland loss is not inevitable. Communities themselves as well as policymakers can make decisions that balance development while preserving agricultural land. Smart growth strategies like easements and improved land use planning can help protect farmland while still allowing our communities to grow.

There are also some very simple steps you as an individual can take to support farmland protection. Make sure you go out and be vocal about supporting local and regional smarter land use policies. Educating yourselves about farmland loss and sharing reliable information with others in your area can raise awareness about the issue. Also make sure to support your local farmers and agricultural markets. This would help strengthen the economic value of farmland and reinforces the importance of preserving agricultural land to those in policymaking.

Farmland to me is more than just open space waiting to be developed. It is the building blocks of our food system, the livelihood of our farmers, and a vital important part of rural communities. If current development trends continue to be unchecked, millions of acres of productive farmland could disappear and who knows how we will be able to provide for our future generations. Protecting farmland today helps ensure that those future generations will still have access to the land that feeds us and thrive for decades to come.

References

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